

Primary Source Reading 1: Reason and Sentiment in Moral Judgment

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.06 — Can Science Ground Ethics? From David Hume, Enquiry Concerning the Principles of Morals, Appendix I (1751)

Before you read: Hume has spent most of the *Enquiry* explaining that virtues are useful and agreeable. Here he asks a sharper question: what faculty actually recognizes that usefulness as praiseworthy? As you read, notice that Hume does not dismiss reason entirely — he gives it real work to do — before arguing that something else must complete the job.

Reason Instructs, Sentiment Distinguishes

But though reason, when fully assisted and improved, be sufficient to instruct us in the pernicious or useful tendency of qualities and actions; it is not alone sufficient to produce any moral blame or approbation. Utility is only a tendency to a certain end; and were the end totally indifferent to us, we should feel the same indifference towards the means. It is requisite a SENTIMENT should here display itself, in order to give a preference to the useful above the pernicious tendencies. This SENTIMENT can be no other than a feeling for the happiness of mankind, and a resentment of their misery; since these are the different ends which virtue and vice have a tendency to promote. Here therefore REASON instructs us in the several tendencies of actions, and HUMANITY makes a distinction in favour of those which are useful and beneficial.

Oedipus and Nero: The Difference Between a Mistake of Fact and a Mistake of Right

After every circumstance, every relation is known, the understanding has no further room to operate, nor any object on which it could employ itself. The approbation or blame which then ensues, cannot be the work of the judgement, but of the heart; and is not a speculative proposition or affirmation, but an active feeling or sentiment.

Hence the great difference between a mistake of FACT and one of RIGHT; and hence the reason why the one is commonly criminal and not the other. When Oedipus killed Laius, he was ignorant of the relation, and from circumstances, innocent and involuntary, formed erroneous opinions concerning the action which he committed. But when Nero killed Agrippina, all the relations between himself and the person, and all the circumstances of the fact, were previously known to him; but the motive of revenge, or fear, or interest, prevailed in his savage heart over the sentiments of duty and humanity. And when we express that detestation against him to which he himself, in a little time, became insensible, it is not that we see any relations, of which he was ignorant; but that, for the rectitude of our disposition, we feel sentiments against which he was hardened from flattery and a long perseverance in the most enormous crimes.

After you read: Hume's example is precise on purpose. Oedipus and Nero both kill a relative, but only Nero is blamed, even though the two cases are factually similar in the killing itself. What differs is not a fact Oedipus failed to grasp and Nero grasped — it is that Nero possessed all the facts and still acted against them. For Hume, this shows that moral blame cannot simply be reasoning about facts, because the facts alone don't distinguish the two cases; something else, a sentiment, has to do that work. As you read Reading 2, watch for what Hume says a sentiment actually *is*, and how it differs from reason as a "faculty."